Talanoa Staff Guide

tah-lah-NOH-ah · Tongan for *talking together*

A picture board that speaks. A resident taps a picture and the phone says the words out loud.

Scan to open Talanoa

https://tcdeveloper27.github.io/Talanoa/

Made for the residents of Faleofaz

What's inside

1. What Talanoa is
2. Setting up a phone
3. The screen at a glance
4. Talking with it
5. Moving between pages
6. The Mom & Dad page
7. The Talk page
8. Show it big · About me
9. Tongan words · your own photos and voices
10. The ABC page
11. The Body and Sick pages
12. Sentences, suggestions and more
13. The Hey and Time pages
14. Staff tools
15. Your own pictures, scenes and stories
16. Stickers, shortcuts and scanning
17. Settings
18. Updates
19. Without Wi-Fi
20. Helping someone talk
21. The paper board
22. If something goes wrong
23. Looking after the phone
24. Asking for changes
25. Credits & contact

1 What Talanoa is

Talanoa helps a person who can't speak tell you what they want, how they feel, and who they want to see. It was made for the residents of Faleofaz.

It works like a set of talking picture cards on a phone (or a tablet). Every picture says a short sentence out loud in a natural voice, for example the carrot picture says *"I want a snack."* The words also appear at the top of the screen, so people nearby can read them (tap them to show them big, section 8), and the picture that said them glows for 30 seconds.

There are 21 pages with 240 pictures in total, plus six important buttons that are always on screen.

Four promises the app keeps

- **It never stays silent.**
  If a voice recording can't play, the phone's own voice says it instead.
- **The top row never moves.**
  Its six buttons are always in the same place, so they can be found without looking.
- **It works without internet**
  once it has been set up.
- **Nothing a resident knows moves unless the family asks.**
  New words only fill empty spots, and new pages go at the end, just before ABC, unless the family asks for another spot.

2 Setting up a phone

You only do this once per phone (a tablet works the same way). It takes a few minutes

and needs Wi-Fi.

1 **Open Google Chrome**

Use Chrome, not a preview from email or Google Drive.

2 **Go to the Talanoa address**

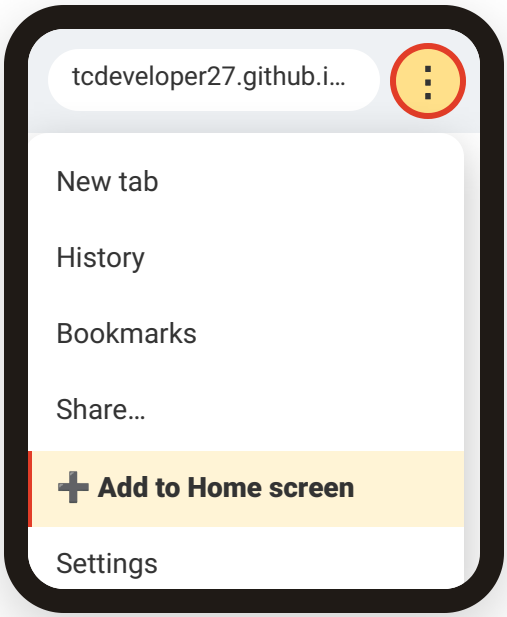
Scan the QR code on the front of this guide with the phone's camera, or type **tcdeveloper27.github.io/Talanoa** (capital T in Talanoa).

3 **Tap the ⋮ menu** (three dots, top right)

Choose **Add to Home screen** or **Install app**, then confirm.

4 **Open Talanoa from its new icon**

It opens full screen like any other app.



Step 3 (illustration). The menu on your phone may look a little different.



Step 4 (illustration). The Talanoa icon on the home screen.

5

Leave Talanoa open on Wi-Fi for a few minutes

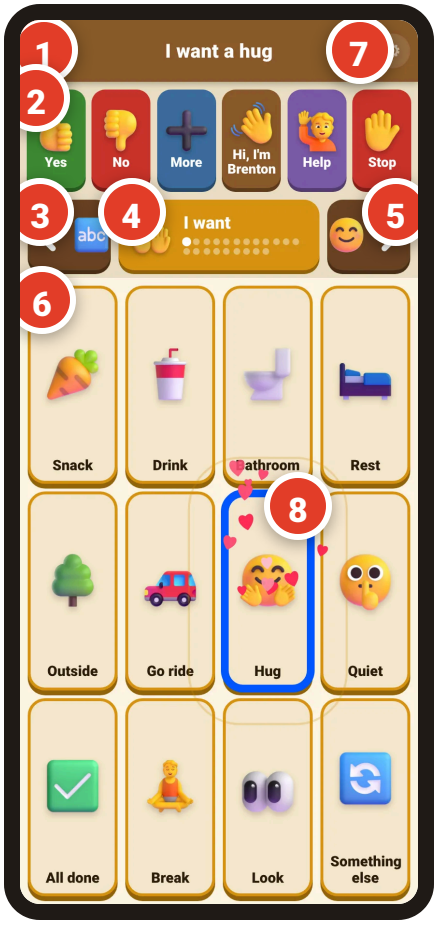
It saves the pictures and the voice onto the phone: about 9,300 short recordings with Michael, the voice it starts with. Tapping the board pauses the saving for a moment. Check in Settings: Status says *Saving the voice for offline use: … of …* while it works (the count goes up by itself while Settings is open), then ✓ **Ready to use with no internet**.

Tip

Turn the media volume up with the side buttons, and set the screen to stay on longer (see section 23).

3 The screen at a glance

This is exactly what residents see. The numbers match the list below.



1 **Spoken words.** Shows what was just said, so staff can read it too; a long sentence is cut short with "…". It flashes green on every picture tap (on the ABC page, when you tap Speak), and goes back to "Tap a picture to talk" after 30 seconds (with **Build sentences** on, the sentence stays until ✕, 🔊, or 2 minutes with nothing added: section 12). **Tap the words to show them full screen** (section 8). A small pie on its right is the wait timer, and a purple bar means a member of staff is modelling (section 14).

2 **The six "always" buttons.** On every page, never moving:

👍 Yes | 👎 No | ➕ More | 👋 Hi, I'm Brenton | 🙋 Help | ✋ Stop

3 **Back arrow ◀.** Goes to the previous page. The small picture shows which page it goes to.

4 **Page name.** Shows which page you're on; the dots show where you are in the pages. **Tap it to see a list of all the pages.**

5 **Next arrow ▶.** Goes to the next page. After the last page it goes back to the first.

6. **Picture tiles.** 12 per page (6 bigger ones with **Bigger pictures**, section 12), always in the same spots. Tap one to speak. Swipe sideways across them to turn the page.

7. **Settings ⚙.** For staff only. It opens only when you **press and hold it for one second**, so residents won't open it by accident.

8. **The glow.** The last picture tapped glows for 30 seconds, so the resident can lift the phone and show you what they said. Tapping another picture moves the glow to it.

It stays upright

Opened from its home-screen icon, Talanoa stays upright even when the phone is turned sideways, so the pictures stay big.

4 Talking with it

Tap a picture once and the phone says the words.

One tap = one sentence

No double-tapping needed. A tap still counts if the finger slides a little or rests on the picture for a while.

Tap again to repeat

It starts again from the beginning.

Quick taps are fine

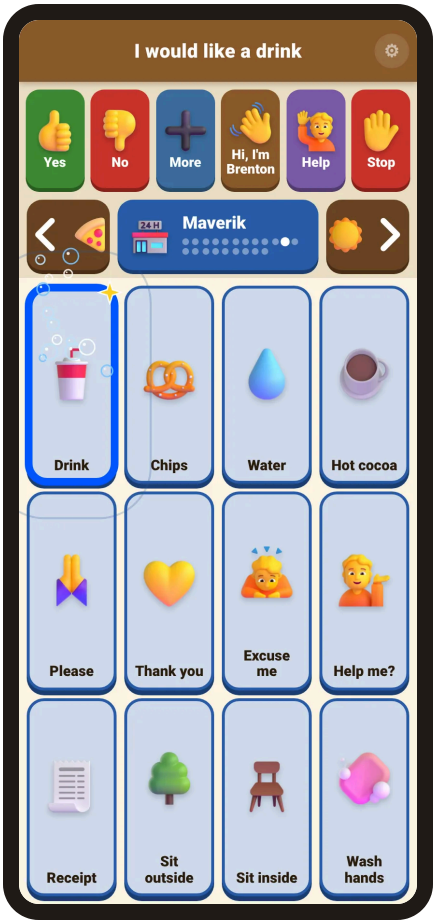
A new tap stops the last sentence and says the new one. Nothing gets stuck.

A little buzz

The phone vibrates slightly on each tap, if it can.

Show someone

The picture glows for 30 seconds, long enough to lift the phone and show a person what was said.



On the **Maverik** page, after tapping **Drink**. The top says "I would like a drink", and Drink glows.

It's fun on purpose

Every tap makes the picture bounce and throws sparkles: confetti for happy words, hearts for hugs, stars on the Toy Story page, bubbles for drinks. Tapping the same picture a few times in a row sets off a shower. Sad or hurt words get just a few gentle sparkles. It's only decoration: it never gets in the way of a tap, and it waits for the voice to start. It can be turned down or off in Settings, and **Calm answers** there gives Yes, No, every feeling and the Talk page the same gentle sparkles, so nobody picks an answer just for the show. On a phone set to reduce animations it starts with just bounces and rings.

5 Moving between pages

Use the big ◀ ▶ arrows to flip through the pages, like turning the pages of a book, or swipe sideways across the pictures.

Swipe to turn the page

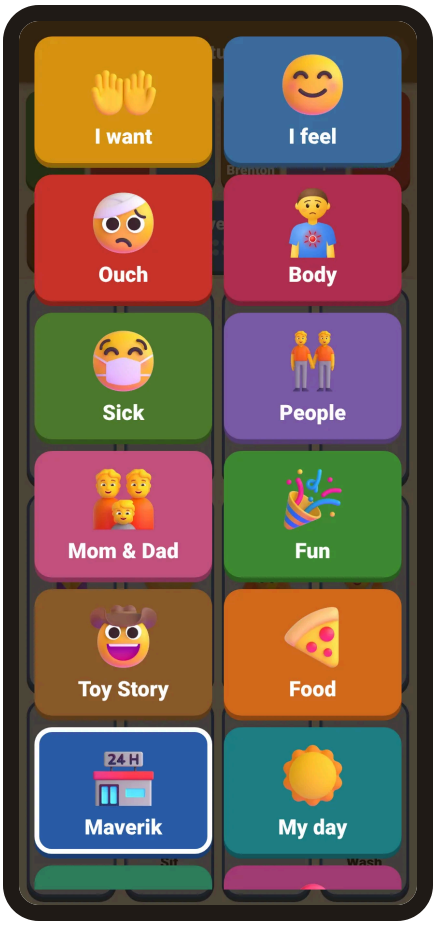
Slide a finger sideways across the pictures, like on a phone's home screen. The page follows the finger; let go early and it springs back. A swipe never says anything.

Or tap the arrows

Each arrow shows a small picture of the page it goes to. After the last page it goes back to the first.

Jump straight to a page

Tap the page name in the middle. All the pages appear as big buttons (scroll down for the rest): tap one to go there. To close the list without choosing, scroll to **✕ Close** at the end, or press Back.



Tapping the page name shows every page (scroll for the rest).

Pages turning by accident?

Swiping can be turned off in Settings. The arrows always work.

The 21 pages, in order

I want 1
12 tiles: Snack, Drink, Bathroom, Rest…

I feel 2
12 tiles: Happy, Excited, Sad, Frustrated…

Ouch 3
12 tiles: Head, Tummy, Throw up, Tooth…

Body 4
12 tiles: Back, Chest, Throat, Neck…

Sick 5
12 tiles: Dizzy, Can't breathe, Bleeding, Fell…

People 6
12 tiles: Family, Staff, Friend, Hi…

Mom & Dad 7
12 tiles: Dad, Call Dad, Dad's house, Dad coming?…

Fun 8
12 tiles: Toy Story, Cartoons, Movie, Costume…

Toy Story 9
12 tiles: Howdy, Bullseye, Infinity, Sky…

Food 10
12 tiles: Hungry, Water, Juice, Milk…

Maverik 11
12 tiles: Drink, Chips, Water, Hot cocoa…

My day 12
12 tiles: Wake up, Breakfast, Lunch, Dinner…

Places 13
12 tiles: Home, My room, Store, Park…

Questions 14
12 tiles: What now?, What's next?, Where to?, Who?…

Things 15
12 tiles: Headphones, Hat, Jacket, Sunglasses…

Talk 16
12 tiles: I like it, Don't like, Again, Wait…

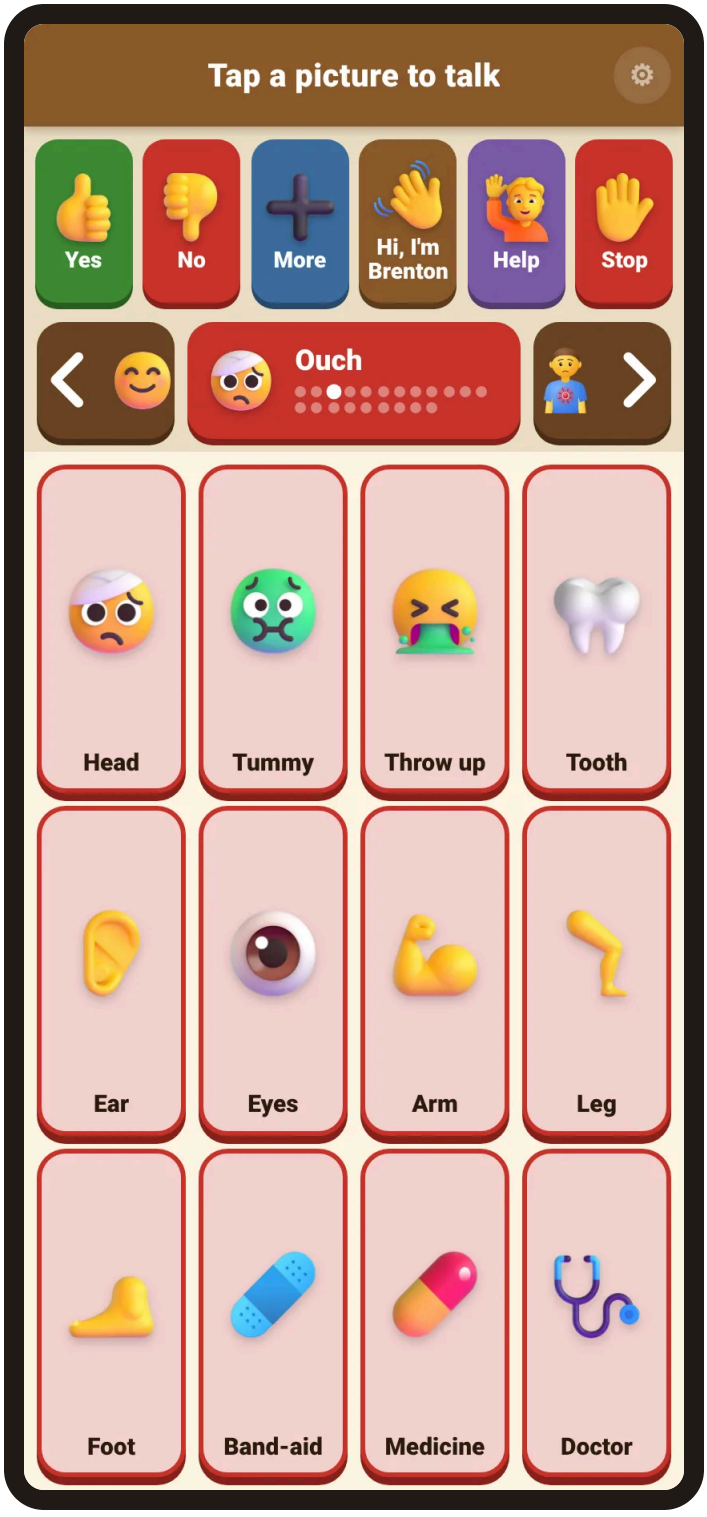
Tongan 17
12 tiles: Mālō e lelei, Mālō, Mālō ‘aupito, ‘Ofa atu…

Words 18
12 tiles: I, You, Want, Like…

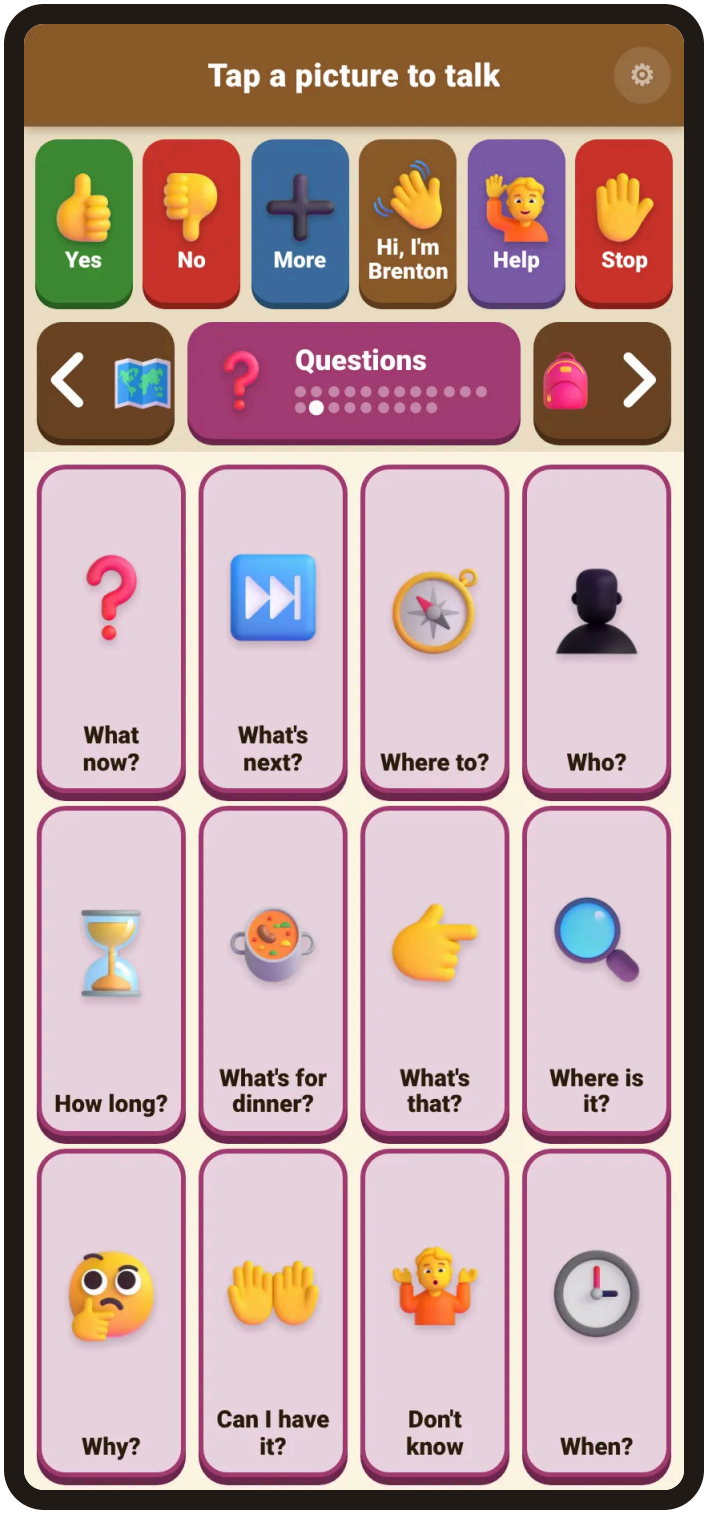
Hey 19
12 tiles: Hey!, Excuse me, Please wait, Listen…

Time 20
12 tiles: What time?, What day?, Dad coming?, How long?…

ABC 21
The alphabet: spell a word, then Speak



Ouch: point to where it hurts.



Questions: what's next, where, who, how long.

Pages can be hidden

If a resident doesn't need a page, it can be turned off on that phone in Settings. New pages usually go at the end, just before ABC (the letter board is always the last page), so the pages a resident knows don't move. The family can ask for another spot: Body and Sick sit right after Ouch, so the health pages are together (section 11).

6 The Mom & Dad page

All the parent and grandparent tiles are together on one page.



Every Dad tile has the matching Mom tile **directly underneath it**: Dad and Mom, Call Dad and Call Mom, Dad's house and Mom's house, Dad coming? and Mom coming? The bottom row has Grandma, Grandpa, Nana and Papa.

This layout is deliberate

The family asked that Mom always appears under Dad. The app is built so this can't be changed by accident.

When a resident taps "Call Dad" or "Call Mom"

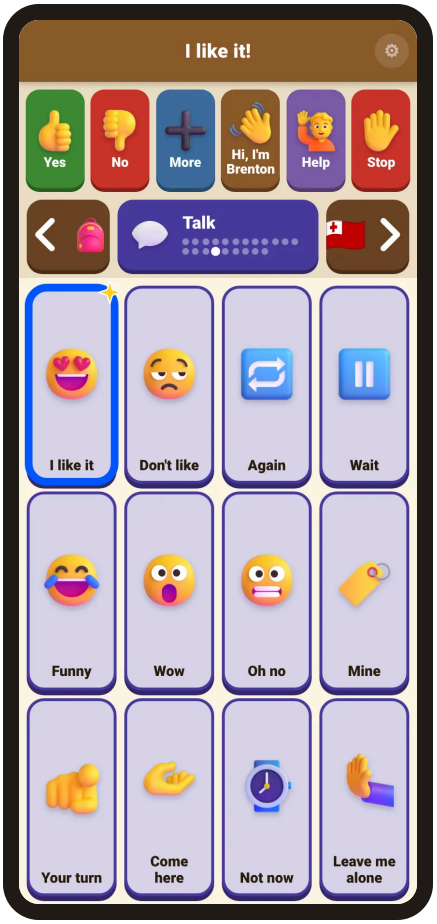
Treat it as a real request: tell them what will happen ("Let's call Mom after lunch") so they know they were heard.

7 The Talk page

Words for saying what they think, not just what they want.

Most of what people say isn't asking for things. It's commenting ("That's funny!"), giving an opinion ("I don't like it"), and steering the conversation ("Wait", "Your turn"). The Talk page gives residents those words too.

Picture	Says
I like it	“I like it!”
Don't like	“I don't like it”
Again	“Again! One more time”
Wait	“Wait, please”
Funny	“That's funny!”
Wow	“Wow!”
Oh no	“Oh no!”
Mine	“That's mine”
Your turn	“Your turn”
Come here	“Come here, please”
Not now	“Not now. Maybe later”
Leave me alone	“Please leave me alone”



The **Talk** page.

"I don't like it", "Not now" and "Leave me alone" are real messages

Honour them whenever you safely can, or say why not: *"Not now? OK. We do have to see the doctor first, then we'll get a drink."* Someone who can say no with words has less need to say it with behaviour.

8 Show it big · About me

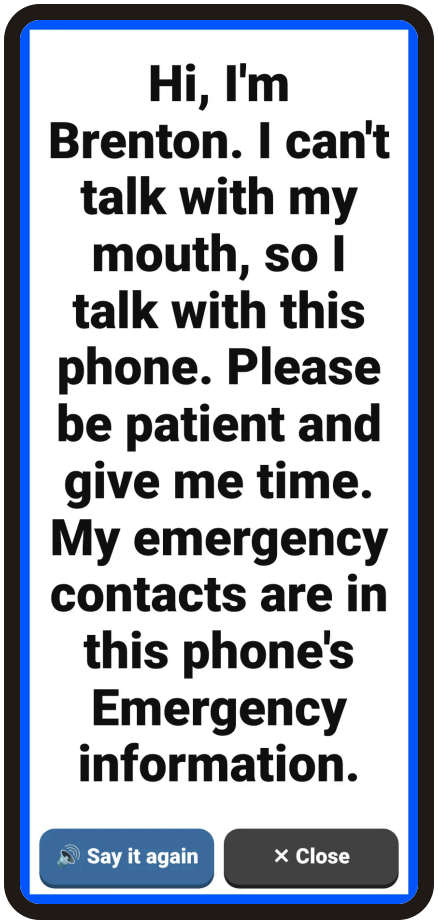
For a cashier, a noisy room, someone across the table, or someone new.

🔎 **Tap the words at the top**

While they're still showing (30 seconds), the last thing said fills the screen in giant letters: hold the phone up, or hand it over. After that, tap the picture again first. 🔊 **Say it again** repeats it. ✕ **Close** (or Back) goes back to the board, and it closes by itself after a minute.

👋 **Hi, I'm Brenton** (top row: about me)

Says: *"Hi, I'm Brenton. I can't talk with my mouth, so I talk with this phone. Please be patient and give me time. My emergency contacts are in this phone's Emergency information."* Tap the words at the top to show them big. Use it with anyone new: a driver, a cashier, a doctor, a police officer or a paramedic. The People page has a short **Hi, I'm Brenton** for a quick hello.



After tapping **Hi, I'm Brenton**, then the words at the top.

Opening by accident?
Settings → **Reading** → untick **Tap the words to show them big**. Then the about-me message can't be shown big either, so tick it again before an outing.

Set up the phone's Emergency information

The about-me message points to the phone's own **Emergency information**. Paramedics and police know to look there, and they can see it from the lock screen without unlocking the phone. Phone numbers and medical details belong there, not in Talanoa, because the Talanoa website is public.

1. **Open the phone's Settings app**
   The phone's own settings (the gear icon among the apps), not Talanoa's ⚙.

2. **Search for "Emergency"**
   Open **Emergency information**. On some phones it's called **Medical info**, or it's inside **Safety & emergency** or the **Personal Safety** app.

3. **Add medical details and emergency contacts**
   Conditions, allergies, medicines, and who to call (family, and Faleofaz).

4. **Turn on "Show on lock screen"**
   To check it: lock the phone, swipe up, tap **Emergency**, then **Emergency information**.

9 Tongan words · your own photos and voices

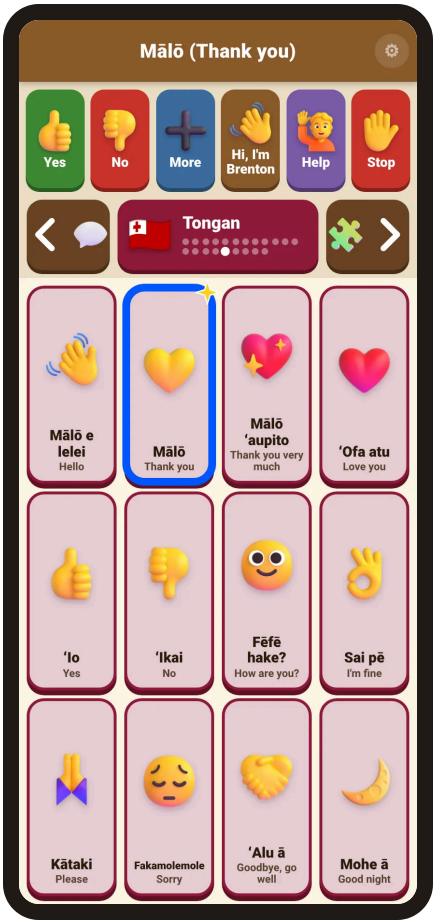
Any picture can show a real photo, and speak in a real person's voice.

The Tongan page

Greetings and everyday words: **Mālō e lelei** (Hello), **Mālō** (Thank you), **Mālō ʻaupito** (Thank you very much), **ʻOfa atu** (Love you), **ʻIo** (Yes), **ʻIkai** (No), **Fēfē hake?** (How are you?), **Sai pē** (I'm fine), **Kātaki** (Please), **Fakamolemole** (Sorry), **ʻAlu ā** (Goodbye, go well), **Mohe ā** (Good night). Each tile shows what it means underneath, and the top of the screen shows both; the voice says just the Tongan word.

Please record them in your own voice

The computer voice can't speak Tongan, so for now it only gets close. A recording by someone from Faleofaz will sound right, and mean much more. It takes about a minute per word (steps below). To add more Tongan words, tell Tim (section 24).

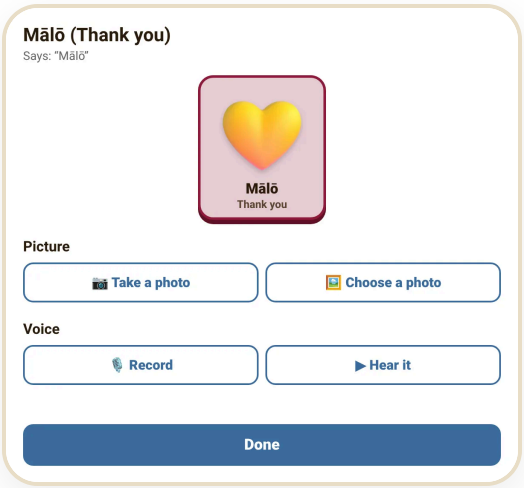


The **Tongan** page.

Record a voice, or add a photo

1 **Hold ⚙ → Photos and voices**

Tap 📷 🎙️ **Change a picture or voice…**



Changing one picture's photo and voice.

2 **Choose the page, then tap the picture**

📷 marks pictures that already have a photo, 🎙️ ones that have a recording.

3 **🎙️ Record, say the words, then ⏹️ Stop**

Find a quiet spot and hold the phone about a hand's width from your mouth. The first time, allow the microphone.

4 **Listen, then ✔ Keep this recording**

Or **✖ Throw it away** and try again. From then on, that picture speaks in your voice. (If you tap Done before choosing, Talanoa asks whether to keep it.)

5 **For a photo: 📷 Take a photo or 🖼️ Choose a photo**

Good for family, staff, a favourite cup, their room, a store they love. **Use the original picture again** undoes it.

They're kept on this phone only, so save a backup

Photos and recordings are never put on the website, so photos of people stay private. It also means a new phone, or removing the app, loses them. Now and then, hold ⚙ → **Save a backup** and email the file to yourself or to Tim. **Restore a backup** puts everything back, on any phone.

To make a whole new picture, or a scene or a story, see section 15.

10 The ABC page

The alphabet, for spelling anything that isn't on a picture.

Tap letters

Each letter says its name. **Space** goes between words, ⌫ takes back one letter, **Clear** starts again.

Speak

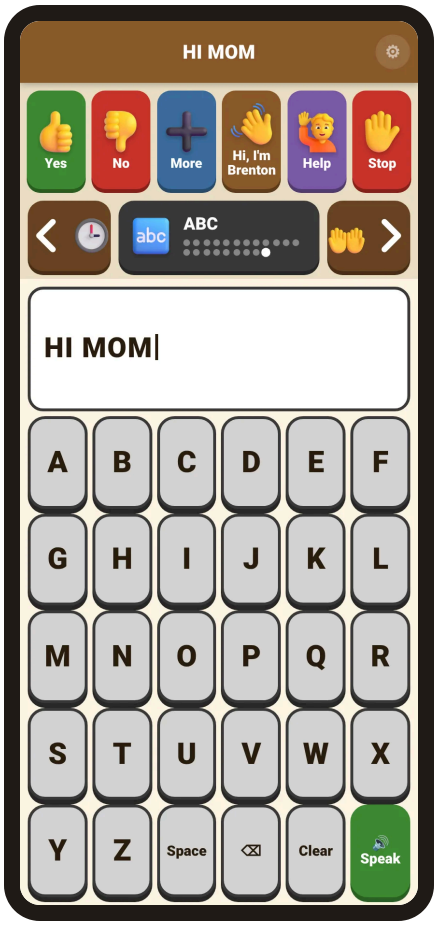
Says the whole word or sentence, and puts it at the top, where it can be shown big.

The same voice as the pictures

The letters and every word on the board are recorded in every voice, and **Michael** (the voice it starts with) also knows about 9,000 everyday words. A word the chosen voice doesn't have (often a name) is spelled out, letter by letter, in that same voice. With **Built-in voice**, the phone's own voice reads it all.

Not spelling yet? That's fine

Let them explore the letters, and read back what they type. Playing with letters is how spelling starts.



HI MOM, typed on the ABC page.

Two extras can be switched on in Settings: **word suggestions** above the letters, and a row

of **numbers** (section 12).

11 The Body and Sick pages

For saying where it hurts, how much, and how they feel when they're unwell. They come right after **Ouch** (pages 4 and 5), so all three health pages are together. Head, Tummy, Tooth, Ear, Eyes, Arm, Leg and Foot are on the Ouch page.

1 **Take every tap seriously**

Treat it as real until you've checked on them, even if they sometimes tap for fun.

2 **Find the spot**

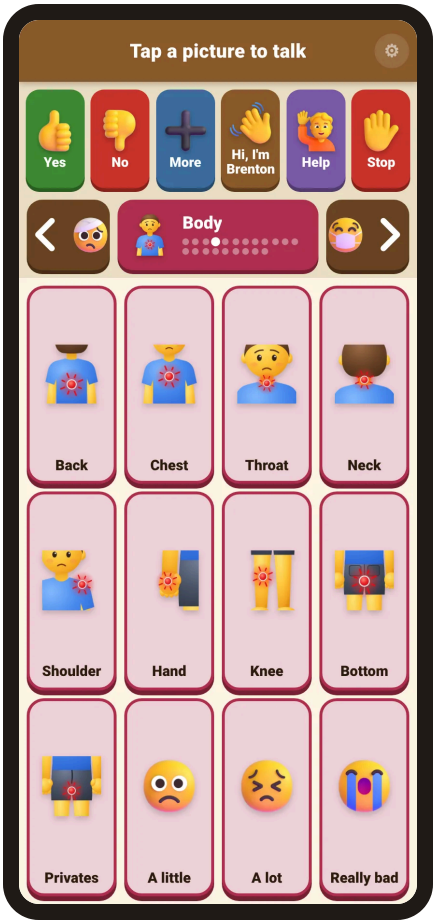
Point and ask: "Does it hurt here?" They can answer with **Yes** and **No** on the top row.

3 **Ask how bad, and since when**

A little, **A lot** or **Really bad** are on the Body page; **Just now** and **Yesterday** are on the Sick page.

4 **Write it down**

What they said and when, for the nurse or doctor. **Better** ("I feel better now") tells you when it has passed.



The **Body** page. The sore spot glows red.

Get help straight away

If they tap **Chest**, **Can't breathe**, **Bleeding** or **Really bad**, follow Faleofaz's procedure for a medical emergency.

Body	Says	Sick	Says
Back	“My back hurts”	**Dizzy**	“I feel dizzy”
Chest	“My chest hurts”	**Can't breathe**	“I can't breathe well”
Throat	“My throat hurts”	**Bleeding**	“I am bleeding”
Neck	“My neck hurts”	**Fell**	“I fell down”
Shoulder	“My shoulder hurts”	**Fever**	“I have a fever”
Hand	“My hand hurts”	**Cough**	“I have a cough”
Knee	“My knee hurts”	**Itchy**	“My skin is itchy”
Bottom	“My bottom hurts”	**Pee hurts**	“It hurts to pee”
Privates	“My private parts hurt”	**Can't poop**	“I can't poop”
A little	“It hurts a little”	**Just now**	“It just started”
A lot	“It hurts a lot”	**Yesterday**	“It started yesterday”
Really bad	“It hurts really bad”	**Better**	“I feel better now”

For appointments

Print just the health pages (Ouch, Body and Sick): hold ⚙ → 🩺 **Health pages to print**, or print Talanoa-Health-Pages.pdf. Take them to the doctor or the hospital.

12 Sentences, suggestions and more

Things other talking apps have, added in October 2026. The Words page, Find a word and This week are always there. The other five are switched on in Settings (section 17) and are **off until someone ticks them**, so the board stays exactly as he knows it.

- **The Words page** (just before ABC): 12 single words, **I, You, Want, Like, Go, Get, Do, Look, More, Not, Different, Finished**. Each says just its word. On their own they answer quickly ("Different!"); with **Build sentences** they combine into things nobody programmed, like *I · Want · Go · Outside*.
- **Build sentences** (Settings → Talking in sentences): every picture is still said straight away, and its words also line up at the top. 🔊 on the left says the whole sentence, one picture

after another; ✕ starts again. Tapping the same picture several times in a row puts it in the sentence once (it's still said every time). After 🔊, the next picture starts a new sentence, and a sentence nothing is added to for 2 minutes clears itself (after 12 pictures the oldest drops off). Tapping the words at the top shows the whole sentence big. Words spoken on the ABC page join the sentence too.

- **Word suggestions on the ABC page**: three words above the letters, finishing the word being typed. Words he has spoken before come first (they're remembered while **Count taps on this phone** is on, and **Clear the counts** forgets them). Tap one to finish the word (it's said, and a space follows).
- **Numbers on the ABC page**: a row of numbers under the letters, 1 to 9 then 0, like a phone keypad. Numbers are said as words: 15 is "fifteen", 2026 "two thousand twenty six".
- **Recent sentences with the big words**: under the big words, the last few things said; tap one to show it and say it again (handy when someone missed it).
- **Bigger pictures (6 on a screen)** (Settings → Screen): for someone who needs bigger targets. Each page becomes two screens, "Food" and "Food 2", in the same order.
- **Find a word** (in Settings, under Pages to show): type part of a word, like *pizz*; it lists each picture that matches and its page (**Pizza** Food page). Tap a result and the board turns to that page and outlines the picture (nothing is said).
- **This week** (Settings → Most-used pictures): taps on each of the last 7 days, and pictures used for the first time this week. Like the other counts, it stays on this phone and is never sent anywhere.

> **Try it on a staff phone first**
> Switch an option on on your own phone and show him: point to I, Want, Go… as you say them. Then decide together, with the family, whether it goes on his phone.

13 The Hey and Time pages

Two pages added in October 2026, just above ABC.

Hey: getting attention, and fixing a mix-up

Hey! and **Excuse me** play a two-note chime, with a soft yellow flash (unless Fun effects are Off), and then the words, so people turn to look first. **Please wait** ("Please wait. I'm finding my words.") also shows the words big, to hold up for a cashier. The rest help when a conversation goes wrong: **Listen** (“Listen to me, please”), **Slow down** (“Please slow down”), **Say it again** (“Can you say that again?”), **Don't understand** (“I don't understand”), **Not right** (“That's not what I meant”), **Not finished** (“I'm not finished”), **Yes or no** (“Ask me a yes or no question”), **Show me** (“Show me, please”), **Thank you** (“Thank you for listening”).



Dad coming? on the Time page: the visit, and the sleeps until then.

Time: questions, with the answer on a card

- **What time?** A clock and the time ("3:15, Saturday afternoon").
- **What day?** Today's date, with this week underneath (a visit day is outlined).
- **Dad coming?** and **Mom coming?** Counts down to the next visit set in Settings → **Visits**: "on Saturday", with a 🌙 for each sleep. With no date set, just the question is said, for you to answer.
- **How long?** The wait timer, if one is running; **What's next?** First / then, if staff have set one (section 14).

- **Now, Later, Morning, Afternoon, Tonight, Tomorrow**: words to answer with.

The question is said first, as always: it's him asking. On the card, 🔊 **Say it** reads the answer in the board's voice ("The time is three fifteen in the afternoon"). ✕ **Close** or Back goes back to the board; the time, date and visit cards also close by themselves after a minute.

14 Staff tools

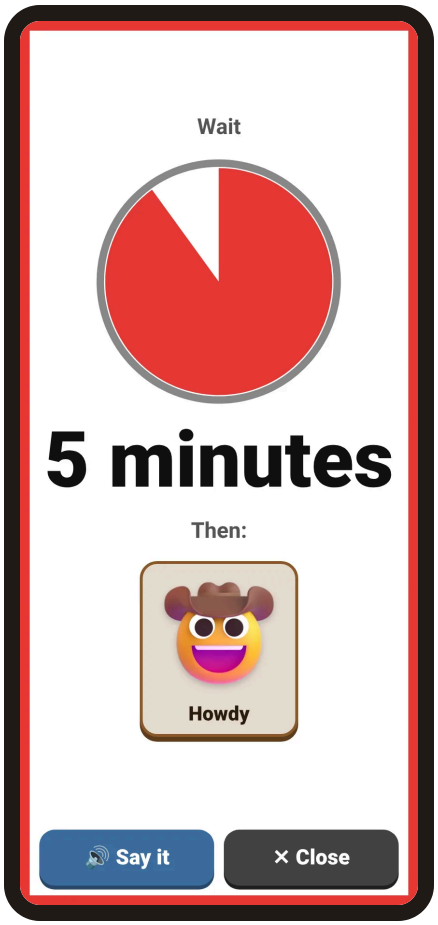
Along the top of Settings (hold ⚙). They're for staff, so they're out of the way of the board.

⏳ Wait timer

Choose how long (1 to 30 minutes) and, if you like, a picture for what comes after ("Then: Toy Story"). A red pie shrinks as the time goes; at the end a chime and "All done waiting!". ✕ **Close** hides it: a small pie stays at the top right of the brown bar, and tapping it shows the timer again. The screen stays on while it runs. To stop it early: ⏳ again → **Stop the timer**.

➡️ First, then

Tap two pictures in order (Shower, then Toy Story). They show big, as **First** and **Then**; "✓ Shower is done" greys out the first. **What's next?** on the Time page shows them again. They're gone by themselves after 12 hours, or ➡️ → **Clear it**.



The wait timer, with what comes next.

Choose between

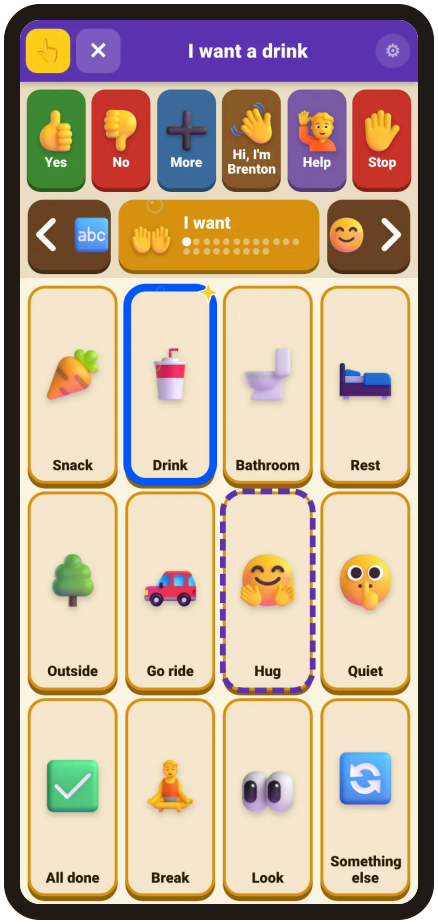
2 to 4 pictures fill the screen for him to choose from: lunch, clothes, an outing. 🔊 asks the choice ("Water, Juice, or Milk?"). The one he taps is said and the others fade; he can still change his mind. Close when you're done.

Modelling

For using his board yourself while you talk with him (section 20). While it's on, the brown bar turns purple and your taps are said but not counted, nor put in today's list. 👆 on the bar, then a picture: that picture glows for a few seconds without a word, a hint for him to tap it himself. ✕ on the bar, or 10 minutes without a tap, switches it off. Also here: **Word of the week**, one picture with a small gold ⭐ for 7 days, to remind everyone to use it.

Stay on this page

At a meal, say: the board stays on the page that's showing. The arrows go, and swiping, the page list and stickers don't turn the page; the top row works as always. Hold ⚙ → 🔓 **Unlock**; it also unlocks by itself after 2 hours.



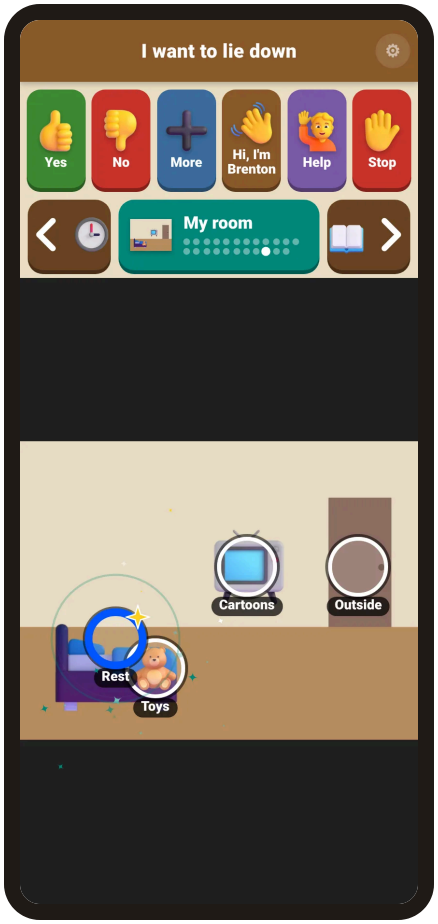
Modelling: the bar turns purple; 👆 gives a hint.

15 Your own pictures, scenes and stories

Made on the phone, kept on that phone only (and in its backups), never on the website.

A new picture

Hold ⚙ → Photos and voices → ➕ **Make a new picture**. Type the words under the picture (and what it says, if that's different), then give it a photo, or one of the board's own pictures (🙂), and a recording if you like. With no recording it talks in the board's voice when the voice has every word (Michael knows about 9,000), one word at a time, otherwise in the phone's own voice; the screen says which. New pictures go on a page called **My pictures**, just above ABC, so nothing he knows moves; **Page** → **A new page…** starts another (Church, Work…). In **Change a picture or voice**, a page made on the phone shows ➕ **New** in its empty spots: tap one to make a picture in that spot. 🗑️ **Delete this picture** leaves its spot empty.



A scene: tap the bed, the TV, the teddy or the door.

A photo from the gallery

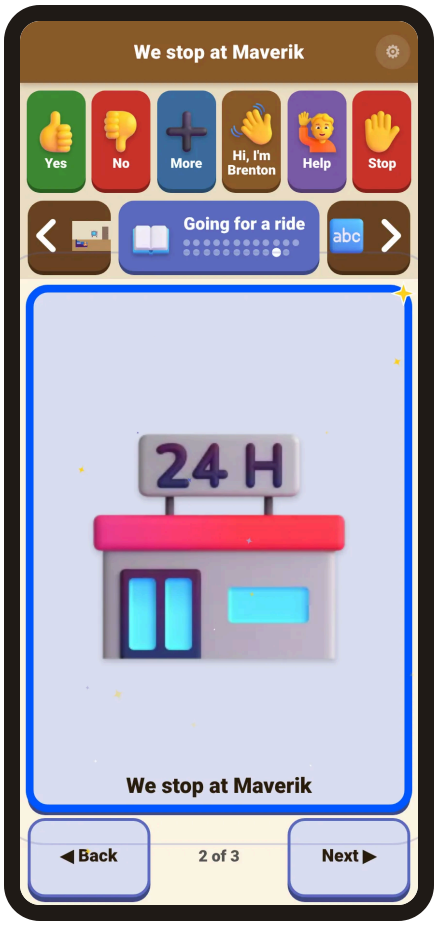
In the phone's Photos or Gallery app: **Share** → **Talanoa**. Talanoa opens and offers to make a new picture with it, or to put it on a picture already on the board. (Only with Talanoa installed on the home screen.)

A whole page in one sitting

In **Change a picture or voice**, choose a page, then 🎙️ **Go through this page, one picture at a time**: record, **Keep**, and the next picture opens by itself. Good for a family member recording all the Tongan words at once.

A scene

🏞️ **Make a scene**: a photo of a real place (his room, the kitchen), with spots to tap. Tap the photo where a spot goes, then choose what it says: one of the board's pictures (the TV says "I want to watch Toy Story") or words you type, which can have a recording. Tap a spot to change or remove it. The scene shows as a page, just above ABC, once it has its photo. Talking about what's in a real place is one of the easiest ways into a talker.



A story, one step at a time.

A story

📖 **Make a story**: a few steps, each a picture and a line ("We get in the car", "The dentist looks at my teeth"). On the board one step shows at a time; **Next ▶** shows the next step and says it, **◀ Back** goes back. For getting ready for something new, or for telling someone what he did.

The scenes and stories on the phone are listed under Photos and voices, to change them later.

Back them up, and pass them on

Save a backup keeps all of it (photos, recordings, new pictures, scenes and stories) in one file. 📤 **Send a backup to another phone** uses Android's share menu: **Quick Share** works with no internet, and email or Messenger work too. On the other phone: **Restore a backup**. Settings shows when the last backup was made, and reminds you after a month.

16 Stickers, shortcuts and scanning

QR stickers

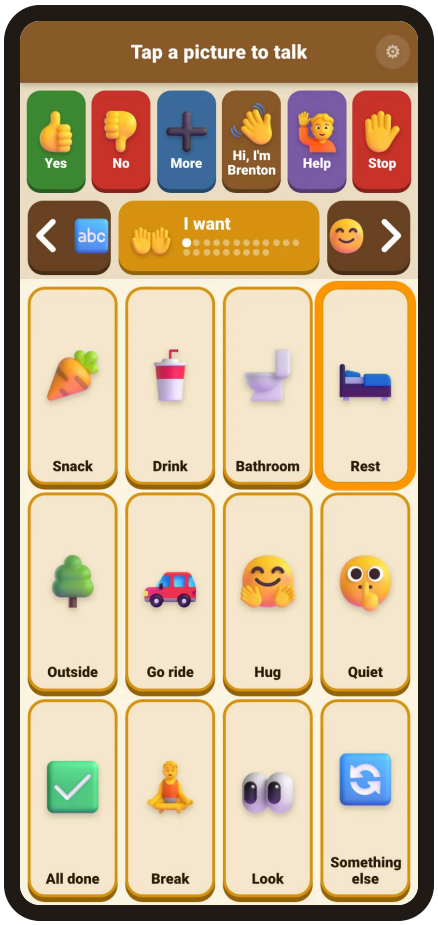
Hold ⚙ → Page stickers → 🏷️ **QR stickers to print**: one for each page, six to a sheet (untick the ones you don't need). Laminate them and stick them where they're needed: Food by the fridge, Places by the door. To use one: tap the page name at the top, then 📷 **Scan a sticker**, and point the camera at it: the board turns to that page. The phone's own camera can scan them too. A sticker only turns the page; it never says anything by itself.



A sheet of QR page stickers.

NFC stickers

On phones with NFC: stickers that work by touch (plain NFC stickers, the kind called NTAG213). In Settings → Page stickers, choose a page, tap **Write a sticker** and hold the sticker to the back of the phone. Then tick **Read NFC stickers while Talanoa is open** (the phone asks once to allow NFC): touching the phone to a sticker opens its page. With Talanoa closed, Android opens it at that page itself.



Scanning: tap anywhere to choose the lit picture.

Shortcuts

Hold Talanoa's icon on the home screen for shortcuts straight to **I want**, **I feel**, **Ouch** and **Food**.

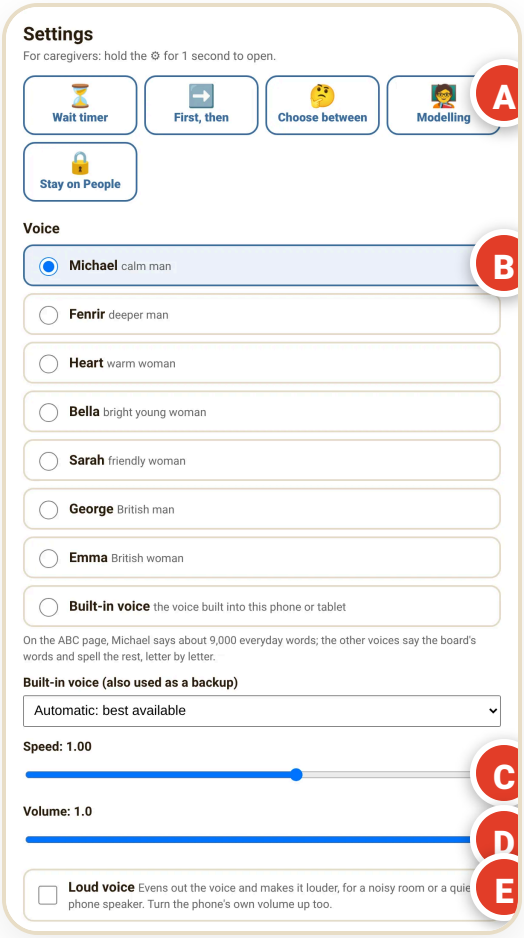
Scanning

Settings → **Scanning** (off to start with), for someone who finds it hard to tap one picture. The pictures light up one after another in an orange frame (the page's pictures, then the ◀ ▶ arrows, then the top row), and a tap **anywhere** below the brown bar chooses the one that's lit: the whole screen is one big button. A switch that types Space or Enter works too. Set how long each one stays lit (1 to 5 seconds); **Rows first** lights a whole row, then its pictures (quicker once he knows it); **Say each picture's name** reads them out as they light up. After 3 rounds with nothing chosen it rests until the next tap. Hold ⚙ for Settings as usual.

17 Settings

Settings belong to each phone. Changing them on one phone doesn't change any other.

Press and hold the ⚙ in the top-right corner
Keep your finger on it for 1 second, then let go



A **Staff tools.** ⏳ Wait timer, ➡️ First, then, 🤔 Choose between, 🧑‍🏫 Modelling and 🔒 Stay on this page (section 14). A tool that's on is shown in blue.

B **Voice.** Tap a name to choose it. You'll hear "Hi! This is my voice." Choose the one that suits the resident. Michael, the one it starts with, is the only one that knows the ABC page's everyday words (section 10). Below the list, **Built-in voice (also used as a backup)** picks which of the phone's own voices fills in when a recording can't play; Automatic is fine.

C **Speed.** Slide left for slower speech, right for faster. 1.00 is normal; the voice keeps its own pitch at any speed.

D **Volume.** The app's own loudness. Also check the phone's side buttons.

E **Loud voice.** Off to start with. Evens out the voice and makes it noticeably louder, without crackling, for a noisy room or a quiet phone speaker. You'll hear the sample voice when you tick it.

The 7 recorded voices, and the phone's own

Voice	Sounds like
Michael default	calm man
Fenrir	deeper man
Heart	warm woman
Bella	bright young woman
Sarah	friendly woman
George	British man
Emma	British woman
Built-in voice	the voice built into the phone or tablet (sound depends on the device)

F

G

H

I

J

K

F **Pages to show.** Untick a page to hide it on this phone; tick it to bring it back. At least one page always stays on.

G **Find a word.** Type part of a word to see which page it's on; tap a result to go there, with the picture outlined (section 12).

H **Swipe to change pages.** On to start with. Untick it if pages turn by accident; the ◀ ▶ arrows always work.

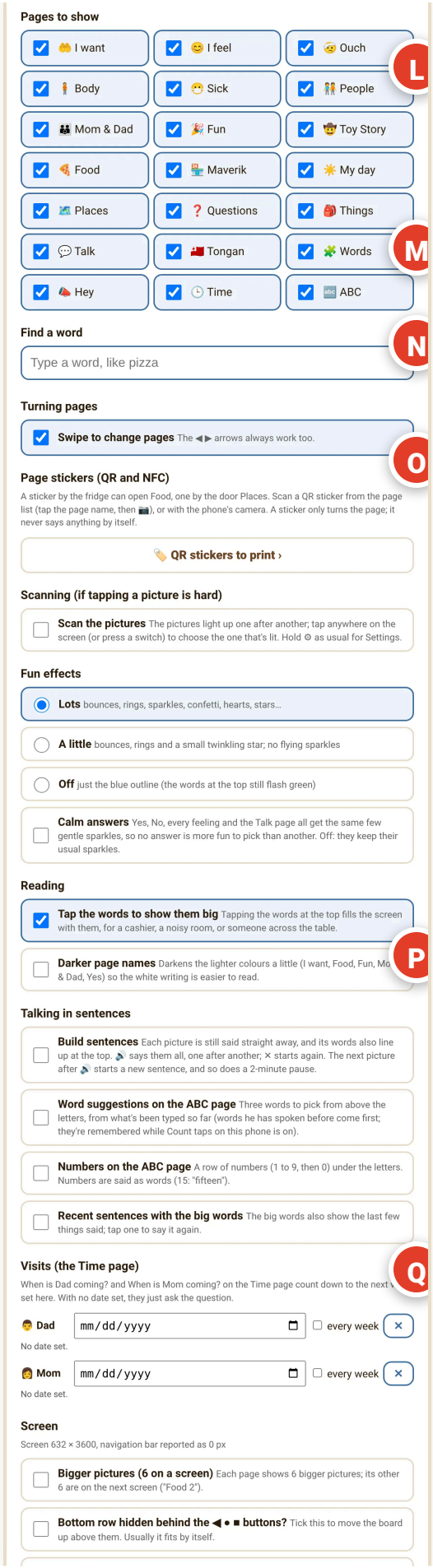
I **Page stickers.** QR stickers to print and, on phones with NFC, stickers to write and read by touch (section 16).

J **Scanning.** Off to start with. The pictures light up one after another, and a tap anywhere chooses the lit one (section 16).

K **Fun effects. Lots** (bounces, rings and sparkles), **A little** (bounces, rings and a small twinkling star) or **Off** (just the blue outline; the words at the top still flash green). Lots to start with, or A little on a phone set to reduce animations. Turn it down if the sparkles distract a resident or the phone feels slow.

L **Calm answers.** Off to start with. When it's on, Yes, No, every feeling and the Talk page all get the same few gentle sparkles, so nobody picks an answer just for the show.

M **Tap the words to show them big.** On to start with (section 8). Untick it if the big words keep opening by accident.

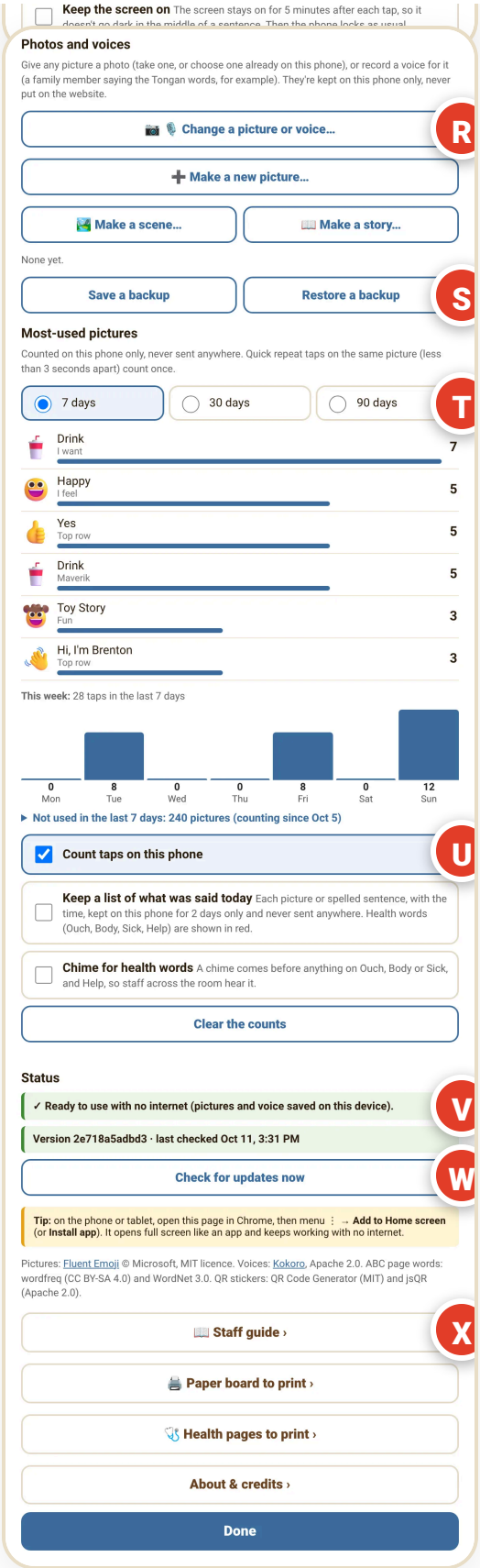


N **Darker page names.** Off to start with. Darkens the lightest colours a little (I want, Food, Fun, Mom & Dad, and Yes on the top row) so the white writing is easier to read.

O **Talking in sentences.** Four extras, all off to start with: **Build sentences**, **Word suggestions** and **Numbers** on the ABC page, and **Recent sentences** with the big words (section 12).

P **Visits.** The date of Dad's and Mom's next visit, and whether it's every week, for **Dad coming?** and **Mom coming?** on the Time page (section 13). Underneath, when the next one is. ✕ clears it.

Q **Screen. Bigger pictures** shows 6 on a screen instead of 12, each page in two ("Food", "Food 2"); off to start with. What Chrome reports about the screen: its size, and the navigation bar's height (often 0, even when there is one). If the bottom row hides behind the ◀ ● ■ buttons, tick **Bottom row hidden…** to move the board up. **Keep the screen on** (off to start with) keeps it on for 5 minutes after each tap, so it doesn't go dark mid-sentence.



R **Photos and voices.** Give a picture a photo, or record a voice for it (section 9); make new pictures, scenes and stories (section 15). The scenes and stories on this phone are listed underneath, to change them.

S **Save a backup · Restore a backup · Send a backup to another phone.** Keeps everything made on this phone safe in one file, puts it back, or sends it to another phone (section 15). Underneath: when the last backup was made.

T **Most-used pictures · This week.** The 20 pictures used most in the last 7, 30 or 90 days; tap the line underneath to see which weren't used in that time. Counted on this phone only and never sent anywhere. Quick repeat taps on the same picture (less than 3 seconds apart) count once, and taps made by staff count too, unless **Modelling** is on. Use it to see which words matter, and to tell the family what's missing. Underneath, **This week** shows the taps on each of the last 7 days and the pictures used for the first time.

U **Count taps · today's list · health chime · Clear the counts. Count taps on this phone** is on to start with. **Keep a list of what was said today** (off to start with) lists each picture and spelled sentence with its time, health words in red, for 2 days only. **Chime for health words** (off to start with) puts the attention chime before anything on Ouch, Body or Sick, and Help, so staff across the room hear it. **Clear the counts** clears the counts, today's list, and the words remembered for word suggestions.

V **Status.** "✓ Ready to use with no internet" means everything is saved (while it's saving, it says how far it has got). Below it you'll see the version and when it last checked for updates.

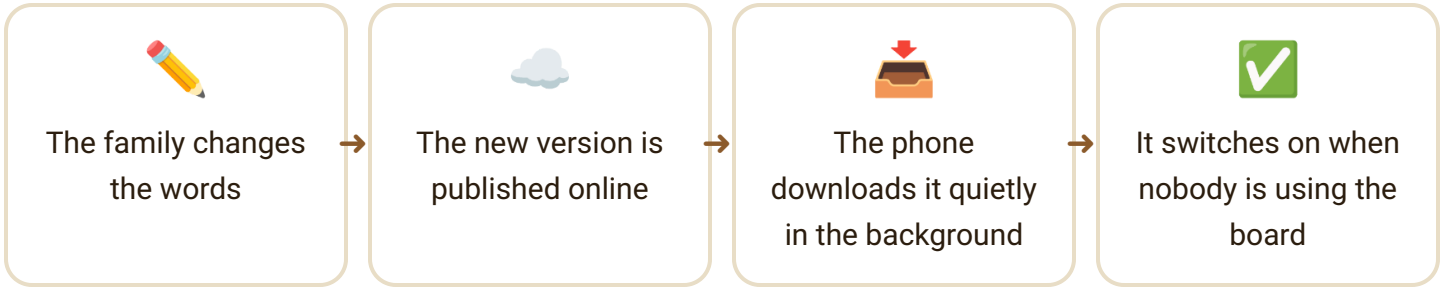
W **Check for updates now.** Gets the newest version straight away (see section 18).

X **Staff guide · Paper board to print · Health pages to print · About & credits.** This guide, the paper board (section 21), just the health pages (section 11), and who made Talanoa. The guide opens with no internet too; the PDFs to print need the internet.

Tap **Done** at the bottom to close Settings.

18 Updates

You don't have to do anything. New words and fixes arrive by themselves.



- The phone checks when Talanoa opens, when the screen turns back on, and every 30 minutes.
- It **never changes while someone is tapping**. It waits until nobody has tapped for 2 minutes, or the screen is off, and then comes back on the same page.
- **To update right now:** hold ⚙ → **Check for updates now**. If there's something new, the app restarts by itself with it.

The message says…	Meaning
✓ You have the latest version.	Nothing to do.
Downloading the new version… the app will restart by itself.	Wait a few seconds.
A new version is ready. It switches on by itself when the board isn't in use, or tap Check for updates now to switch now.	It will update on its own soon; tap the button to switch straight away.
Could not check: no internet connection right now.	Connect to Wi-Fi and try again. The board still works normally.

19 Without Wi-Fi

Once the phone shows ✓ **Ready to use with no internet**, Talanoa works anywhere: on outings, in the car, at the store, or when the Wi-Fi is down. Pictures, words and the chosen voice are all saved on the phone.

> **After choosing a new voice**
> Keep the phone on Wi-Fi until Settings → Status says ✓ **Ready to use with no internet**: about a minute for most voices, several minutes for Michael (it also saves the ABC page's 9,000 words). Until then, a sentence that isn't saved yet plays from the internet, and with no internet the phone's own voice says it. It's never silent.

20 Helping someone talk

The most helpful thing staff can do costs nothing: use the board yourself, every day.

🗣️ **Use the board when you talk to them**

As you speak, tap the main word on their board: "Let's go to *Maverik*", "Do you want *more*?" Children hear thousands of hours of talk before they say a word; someone learning a talker needs to see it used the same way. Ask first ("Can I show you on your phone?"), or point to the paper board instead. Switch on **Modelling** first (section 14), so your taps aren't counted as his.

🚫 **Show, don't test**

No quizzing ("Show me Drink!"). Just use the words naturally while you talk.

⏳ **Wait**

After a question, count to ten in your head before helping. Finding the right page and picture takes time.

💬 **Answer every message, even when the answer is no**

"I hear you, you want a drink. We'll get one after lunch." That's how people learn their words work.

🙅 **No means no**

"No", "Stop", "Not now" and "Leave me alone" are real. Respect them whenever you safely can, or explain why not.

🎈 **Playing with it is learning**

Tapping lots of pictures, or the same one again and again, is how people explore their words, the way a baby babbles. Don't stop it: say the words back, and join in.

📍

It's their voice: keep it with them

All day, charged, in every room. **Never take the board away** as a punishment or to get someone to behave.

📈

Notice what's missing

Settings → **Most-used pictures** shows which words get used (your own taps count too, unless Modelling is on). When someone seems to want a word that isn't there, tell the family.

Everyone has the right to communicate

The Communication Bill of Rights (ASHA, 3rd edition, 2024) lists twelve rights. They include: to be treated with dignity and respect; to communicate in a way that fits their culture and language; to be spoken to directly, not talked about; to get a response to every message, even when the answer is no; to ask for things and to refuse them; to share feelings, comments and opinions; to make real choices; and to have a working talker with them at all times. asha.org/njc/communication-bill-of-rights

Free training

Project Core has 12 short, free training modules on teaching with a talker. They're made for schools, but the ideas work at any age.

Talanoa supports, it doesn't replace

Talanoa is a simple, friendly board, not a full professional speech system. A speech-language pathologist who specializes in AAC can suggest what each resident needs.

21 The paper board

Every page on paper, in the same colours and places as on the phone (the ABC sheet is a

simple letter board).

For when the phone is charging, lost or broken; for the shower, the bath, the pool or the rain; and to point to words while you talk.

1 **Print it**

Hold ⚙ → 🖨️ **Paper board to print**, then 🖨️ **Print**. Or print the ready-made PDF: Talanoa-Paper-Board.pdf. Card stock is best.

2 **Laminate the sheets**

Keep them on a ring, in the same order as the phone's pages: one set in their bag, one at home.

3 **Cut out the About me card**

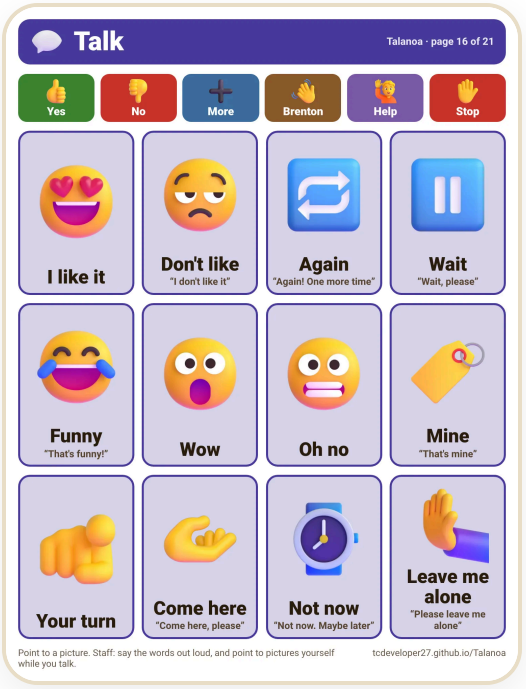
It's on the cover. Keep it in a wallet or bag.

4 **Just the health pages**

For doctor and hospital visits: hold ⚙ → 🩺 **Health pages to print** (Ouch, Body and Sick), or Talanoa-Health-Pages.pdf (section 11).

Photos too

Opened on the resident's own phone, the paper board uses the photos saved on that phone, and includes the pages of pictures made on it. For QR stickers that open a page, see section 16.



One sheet: the page name, the top row, then the 12 pictures, with what each one says written underneath when it's more than its name.

22 If something goes wrong

What you notice	What to do
No sound at all	Turn the volume up with the phone's side buttons. Check the phone isn't on silent. In Settings, check **Volume** isn't low.
The voice sounds robotic	In Settings, **Built-in voice** is probably chosen. Choose **Michael** (or another named voice). If a named voice is already chosen, the phone's own voice is filling in because that voice isn't saved on the phone yet: connect to Wi-Fi and wait for ✓ **Ready to use with no internet** (section 19).
Only a brown bar, no pictures	It was opened in a preview (from email or Google Drive). Open Talanoa from its home-screen icon, or in Chrome.
A page is missing	Settings → **Pages to show** → tick it.
Settings won't open	Press and **hold** the ⚙ for a full second. A quick tap does nothing, on purpose.
New words from the family aren't showing	Connect to Wi-Fi, then Settings → **Check for updates now**.
"404 / There isn't a GitHub Pages site here"	The address was typed wrong. Use the QR code, or type **tcdeveloper27.github.io/Talanoa** with a capital T.
The ▶ arrow (or a swipe) jumped back to "I want"	That's normal: after the last page it starts again at the first.
Pages keep turning by accident	Settings → untick **Swipe to change pages**. The ◀ ▶ arrows still work.

The words keep adding up at the top, with 🔊 and ✕	That's **Build sentences** (section 12): each picture's words line up so 🔊 can say them all. ✕ clears them. To turn it off: Settings → Talking in sentences → untick **Build sentences**.
Only 6 pictures on a screen, and pages called "Food 2"	That's **Bigger pictures** (section 12). To go back to 12: Settings → Screen → untick **Bigger pictures**.
The bar at the top is purple, with 👆 and ✕	**Modelling** is on (section 14): taps aren't counted. Tap ✕ on the bar to switch it off; it also goes off by itself after 10 minutes without a tap.
The ◀ ▶ arrows are gone and the page won't turn	**Stay on this page** is on (a 🔒 shows by the page name). Hold ⚙ → 🔓 **Unlock**. It also unlocks by itself after 2 hours.
Pictures keep lighting up in an orange frame, and tapping a picture doesn't say it	That's **Scanning** (section 16): a tap anywhere chooses the lit picture. To turn it off: Settings → Scanning → untick **Scan the pictures**.
A small round pie or a green ✓ at the top right	The **wait timer** (section 14). Tap it to see the timer; after it ends, Close clears it.
A chime before some words	That's **Hey!** and **Excuse me** on the Hey page, or **Chime for health words** (Settings → Most-used pictures).
A gold ⭐ on a picture	The **word of the week** (Settings → 🧑‍🏫 Modelling). It goes after 7 days.
📷 Scan a sticker says the camera didn't start	In Chrome: ⋮ → **Settings** → **Site settings** → **Camera**, and allow **tcdeveloper27.github.io**.
A picture is glowing	That's the last picture tapped. It stops glowing by itself after 30 seconds, or as soon as another picture is tapped.
Too many sparkles, or the phone feels slow	Settings → **Fun effects** → **A little** or **Off**.

The words suddenly filled the whole screen	That's **Show it big** (section 8). Tap ✕ **Close** or Back; it also closes by itself after a minute. To stop it opening by accident: Settings → **Reading** → untick **Tap the words to show them big**.
"The microphone didn't start" when recording	Close any call or other app using the microphone. Then in Chrome: ⋮ → **Settings** → **Site settings** → **Microphone**, and allow **tcdeveloper27.github.io**. Try again.
A photo or recording has disappeared	They're kept on the phone only. Hold ⚙ → **Restore a backup** and pick the backup file.
The Tongan words don't sound right	The computer voice can't speak Tongan. Record them in a real voice (section 9).
The ABC page spells a word out instead of saying it	With **Michael** (the voice it starts with) it says the words on the board and about 9,000 everyday words; the other voices know the board's words and the number words. Any other word (often a name) is spelled out in the same voice. To have a word added, tell Tim (section 24).
The bottom row is hidden behind the phone's ◀ ● ■ buttons	Close Talanoa and open it again (it fits itself to the phone the first time). If it's still hidden: Settings → **Screen** → tick **Bottom row hidden behind the ◀ ● ■ buttons?**
The screen keeps turning off	See "Screen timeout" in section 23.
Something else looks wrong	Close Talanoa completely and open it again from its icon. If it still happens, take a photo of the screen and email it to Tim Broussard at tcdeveloper@gmail.com.

23 Looking after the phone



Charge every night

A flat battery means a resident with no voice.



Volume

Use the side buttons while Talanoa is talking to set how loud it is.

Screen timeout

On most Android phones: **Settings** → **Display** → **Screen timeout**, and choose a longer time (for example 10 minutes). Or, in Talanoa: Settings → Screen → **Keep the screen on** (5 minutes after each tap).

Clean and protect

Wipe the screen with a slightly damp cloth. A sturdy case is a good idea.

Loud places

A small clip-on Bluetooth speaker makes the voice easier to hear in shops and cars (Bluetooth adds a short delay before each sentence). Show it big helps too (section 8).

Emergency information

Set it up once, so first responders can see it on the lock screen (section 8).

24 Asking for changes

New words, different wording, a real photo of someone instead of a picture: the family can add these. Write down what's needed (for example *"add Swing, 'I want to go on the swing'"*) and pass it to **Tim Broussard**. The change reaches the phone automatically, usually the same day. Settings → **Most-used pictures** can help decide what to add. A photo of a person is best added on the phone itself (section 9), so it stays private: anything Tim adds goes on the public website.

Tim Broussard

✉️ tcdeveloper@gmail.com

25 Credits & contact

Talanoa was made with love for the residents of Faleofaz, by:

Tim Broussard
tcdeveloper@gmail.com

Brenton Broussard

Legion

Faleofaz

Faleofaz

📞 801-317-5454

✉️ faleofaz@utfaleofaz.org

📍 West Valley City, Utah, serving Salt Lake County residents

📷 @faleofaz_llc · 🌐 faleofaz.org

Pictures: Fluent Emoji © Microsoft (MIT licence). Voices recorded with Kokoro, an open-source speech model (Apache 2.0). ABC page words: chosen with wordfreq by Robyn Speer (data CC BY-SA 4.0) and WordNet 3.0 © 2006 Princeton University. QR codes: QR Code Generator by Kazuhiko Arase (MIT licence) and jsQR by Cosmo Wolfe (Apache 2.0). "QR Code" is a registered trademark of DENSO WAVE INCORPORATED.